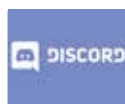




MSI launches 3 gaming Laptops

The MSI GP Leopard, Pulse GL, Katana GF series gaming laptops are all loaded to set foot in India. <https://digit.in/aug21-03>



Malware through Discord

Leading cybersecurity firm Sophos warned that Discord is being used by hackers to spread malware. <https://digit.in/aug21-04>

hole is discovered, an exploit mechanism that enables potentially complete access to the operating system and the device is developed. This is then used across popular applications such as WhatsApp or iMessage, for instance. As an example, a skillfully crafted message to your phone, is sufficient to cause an exploit of the discovered vulnerability, resulting in the device being completely taken over by the spyware.”

These are among the most sophisticated tools that you can see, where the attacker uses the most up to date and cutting edge tools to get a foothold on the system. Krishnapur tells us, “think of it as a thief in the real world who goes around a home that is locked looking for openings (research) and finds an open window that someone forgot to lock (vulnerability enabling ‘zero-click’ – no need to knock on the door). It is an open sesame post that, and what the thief can do inside the home is left to anyone’s imagination (exploit).”

Once Pegasus gets a foothold on the device, it becomes a persistent and modular platform. A remote operator can then snoop into all the calls, messages, photos, GPS and the data flying between the social media, email and instant messaging apps.

The persistence also allows remote commandeering of the mic and camera on the device. A Pegasus operative can access the plaintext messages before the instant messenger apps encrypt them and send them across to the recipient. Krishnapur explains, “once installed, Pegasus can set up shop within the phone, harvest almost any information or extract any file, messages, address books, call history, calendars, emails, and internet browsing history and transmit it back to its controllers through anonymised network servers. Instead of attempting to eavesdrop on data flowing between two devices, which will most likely be encrypted, Pegasus lets its deployers hijack and commandeer the device itself, obtaining access to everything on it.”

To the infected user, the instant messaging apps work as intended. As Krishnapur says, “cyber weaponry has come a long way, with Pegasus now considered one of the most advanced Android and iOS spyware to have ever been created. The stealth and self-destruction mechanisms through fileless operations, makes it a sophisticated and a formidable cyber weapon from a counter surveillance standpoint. It is a modular malware, malicious and untraceable, dubbed to be the ‘ultimate surveillance tool’.” Pegasus itself encrypts all the data that it uses, and actively tries to avoid

with you, but virtually it will belong to someone else.”

The Citizen Lab has been tracking the spyware since 2016, when a threat actor known as Stealth Falcon put up a homepage with a link directly into Pegasus infrastructure, exposing the spyware in the process. We asked Mahadeshwar what are the implications of an infection, “Pegasus spyware can extract all of your data because it can be planted via an attacker or by a hacker who is hired. Moreover, the data can be taken by the hacker or the hosting provider whose servers are hosting the data. If



Taking an encrypted backup of a phone. Remember not to forget your password.

detection using code obfuscation, and can wipe itself from the system if needed. This makes it difficult to detect using typical counter surveillance tools. Mahadeshwar says, “Pegasus is a type of spyware that is highly sophisticated in nature. The spyware can access your phone, whether Android or iOS. It has been known to attack even the latest versions of these smartphones. The various ways in which Pegasus attacks your smartphone includes detecting zero-day vulnerability and taking advantage of that, and as it gets into your phone, it can gain access to all your information, like contacts, call logs, microphones, and WhatsApp chats. Physically, the phone will be

spyware is installed on your device, it can expose all your private data, including your identity, your text messages, and financial details such as your bank account and other banking details, resulting in reputational damage and financial losses.”

Cyberlaw expert Adv. Prashant Mali gave us some simple tips on how all of us can protect ourselves from spyware such as pegasus. “Update your phone OS. Watch your data consumption. Keep a check in spite of turning off your data connection, to see if it gets turned on automatically after some time. You can use the tool kit given on Amnesty International website to detect whether your phone is infected or not.”